

Condemning the railways

The launch of the railways in the Indian subcontinent and the making of the Mahatma (great soul) were both epoch-making events in the 19th century. While Gandhi lived and worked in South Africa from 1893 to 1914, his interaction with the railways was one of withstanding racial prejudice and discrimination. A lot of his writings on the discrimination faced by Indians in South Africa addressed the ban on travelling in trams and first-class carriages. In *The Grievances of the British Indians in South Africa: An Appeal to the Indian Public (The Green Pamphlet)*, he wrote several sections on the indignity of travelling on trams and trains for a "coolie". This was reported in *The Natal Mercury* issue of 18 January 1897.

In 1909, Gandhi wrote *Hind Swaraj*, or *Indian Home Rule*, which went on to be labelled as seditious and was banned. It was a critique of industrialization and the civilizational impulse of the West. Deeply critical of the railways, Gandhi viewed it as symptomatic of a larger denigration of the Indian way of life. A colonial tool, to him it was "beyond dispute that they propagate evil".

By 1915, when Gandhi made his final move to India, the railways had become a part of the physical and social fabric of the country. His mentor GK Gokhale had advised him to travel across the country before launching into active politics.